Build Strategy

College Application Navigator — Phased Development Plan

Guiding Principle

Build the simplest useful version first (MVP), then layer in AI, automation, and polish. This ensures the project is usable even if time runs out, and makes it easy for future League students or staff to pick up where you left off.

Phase 1: MVP — Core Structure & Static Screens

Goal: A working, navigable app with all 9 screens visible, even if not fully functional yet.

What to build:

- User sign-up/login (name, grade, high school, email)
- Navigation between all 9 screens
- Static versions of each screen (forms, checklists, placeholder text)
- Basic questionnaire forms that collect and display user input
- A simple dashboard/home screen showing the user's name and progress

What to skip for now:

- AI recommendations
- Real deadline scraping
- Reminders/notifications
- Data persistence (saving between sessions)

Done when: A user can sign up, click through all 9 screens, and fill out forms — even if nothing is saved or recommended yet.

Phase 2: Data & Persistence

Goal: The app remembers what the user entered.

What to build:

- Connect a database (or simple file-based storage) so user data saves between sessions
- User profile stores: grade level, GPA, test scores, interests, extracurriculars, college list
- Checklist progress saves (e.g., Letter of Rec steps)
- College list saves (Screen 3)
- 4-year course plan saves (Screen 1)

Done when: A user can close the app and return to find all their data intact.

Phase 3: AI Recommendations

Goal: Claude provides personalized suggestions based on user input.

What to build (using Claude API):

- **Screen 1**: Recommend extracurriculars, volunteer opportunities, summer programs based on interests questionnaire
- **Screen 1**: Warn users if their course load is too heavy
- **Screen 1**: Suggest courses based on interests and college expectations
- **Screen 2**: Help user decide SAT vs. ACT based on questionnaire
- **Screen 3**: Recommend colleges and majors based on goals and interests
- **Screen 7**: Give pros/cons of accepted schools based on user preferences
- **Screen 8**: Recommend scholarships based on profile

Done when: After filling out a questionnaire, the user sees AI-generated, personalized recommendations.

Phase 4: Browser MCP — Live Web Data

Goal: Claude pulls real, up-to-date info from the web.

What to build (using Browser MCP):

- **Screen 4 ("Why Us?" Assistant)**: Claude searches a school's website and returns specific details to help with supplemental essays
- **Screen 9 (Deadline Tracker)**: Claude scrapes application deadlines from each school on the user's college list and populates a calendar automatically

Done when: A user can enter a school name and get real-time deadline info and school-specific essay material pulled from the web.

Phase 5: Reminders & Timeline Features

Goal: The app proactively guides users with timely nudges.

What to build:

- In-app reminder system (banners or notifications when deadlines are approaching)
- Timeline view for essay writing schedule (Screen 4)
- AP exam study schedule generator based on selected AP courses (Screen 2)
- Letter of Rec checklist with date-based reminders (Screen 5)
- CSU / Common App / UC open date reminders (Screen 6)

Done when: The app surfaces the right reminder at the right time without the user having to manually check.

Phase 6: Polish & Handoff

Goal: Make the app presentable, stable, and easy for others to continue.

What to build:

- Clean, mobile-friendly UI
- Onboarding flow (the "separate email" recommendation, grade-appropriate screen unlocking)
- Error handling and input validation
- A README and contributor guide for future developers
- Docker setup finalized so anyone can run it

Done when: The app looks professional, handles edge cases gracefully, and a new developer can get it running in under 30 minutes using the Getting Started Guide.

Summary Timeline

Phase	Focus	Can be done in 8 hrs?
Phase 1: MVP	All screens, static forms, navigation	✅ Yes — start here
Phase 2: Data	Saving user input	🟡 Partial — basic saving is feasible
Phase 3: AI	Claude recommendations	🟡 1-2 screens possible
Phase 4: Browser MCP	Live deadline scraping, "Why Us?"	❌ Future work
Phase 5: Reminders	Timeline nudges	❌ Future work
Phase 6: Polish	UI, handoff docs	🟡 Basic polish yes

For Future Contributors

Each phase is self-contained. If you're picking this up from a previous student:

1. Read the Getting Started Guide to run the project
2. Check which phase was last completed (look for a `PROGRESS.md` in the repo)
3. Pick up at the next phase — you don't need to redo earlier work